# Student Evaluations of Teaching

Idaliya Grigoryeva • University of California, San Diego

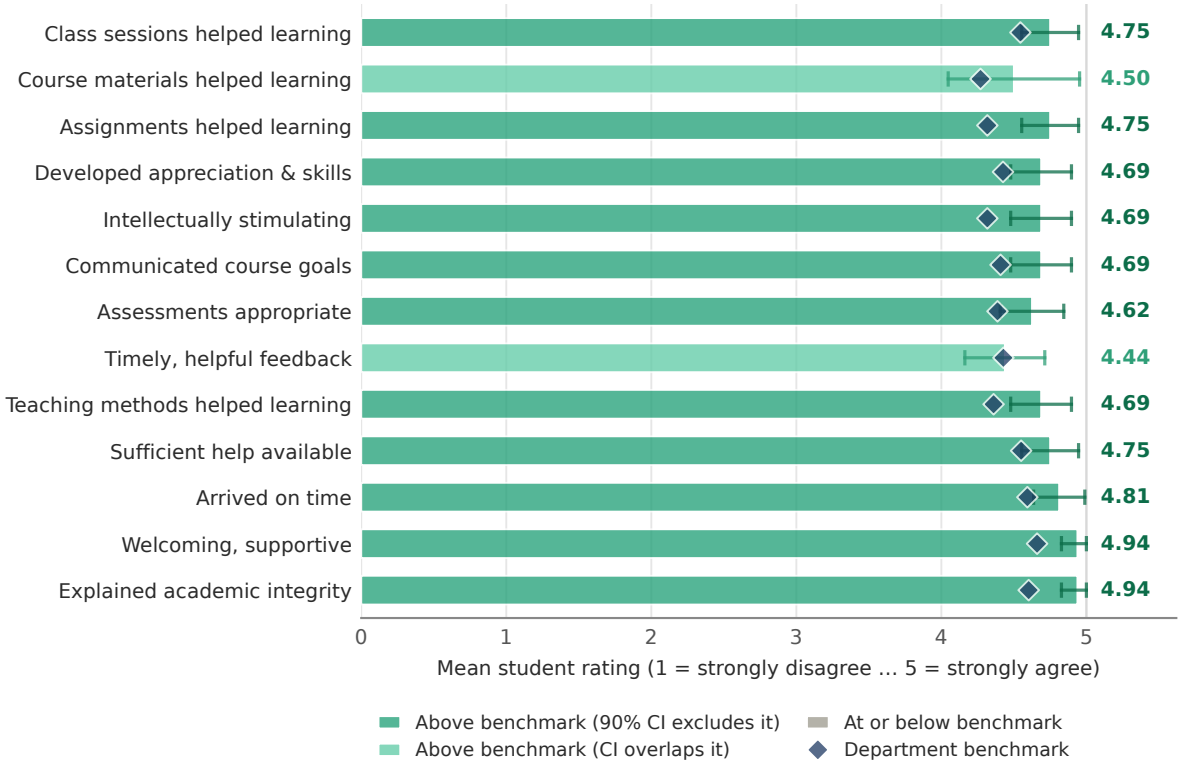
Student ratings, 2022-2026 • instructor of record and teaching / instructional assistant

The data presented below are based on UC San Diego's official end-of-term evaluation surveys, roughly **370 student evaluations** collected between 2022 and 2026: two courses as instructor of record (ECON 5 and ECON 121, three sections, $n = 32$) and eighteen discussion and lab sections as a teaching / instructional assistant ($n \approx 336$) in ECON 5, ECON 100A, ECON 121, ECON 171, ECON 190, and GPEC 443. All ratings are on the standard five-point scale (5 = strongly agree). Bars show the mean, with a 90% confidence interval where per-response data are available; where a departmental comparison exists it is drawn as a diamond, and the bar is colored by whether the rating exceeds that benchmark (see the note at the end).

## Instructor of record

As instructor of record, Ida's ratings exceed the departmental benchmark on every item, and on **11 of 13 items** the 90% confidence interval clears the benchmark when the two most recent courses are pooled (Figure 1). The benchmark is the mean across all Economics Summer-Session-I courses at the same level.

**Figure 1.** Instructor of record: pooled across ECON 5 and ECON 121 (Summer 2025, $n = 16$)



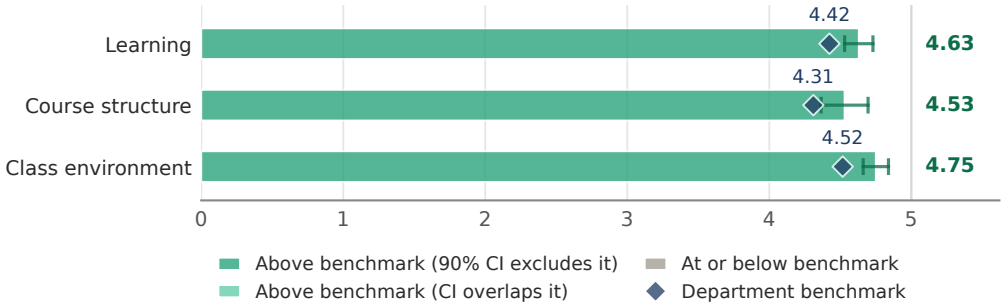

*Notes.* Bars are the pooled mean with a 90% $t$-CI (whisker capped at the 5.0 ceiling); the CI and the value label take their bar's shade. The diamond is the departmental benchmark: the two courses' published benchmarks, weighted by each course's number of responses to the item. Bar shades separate items whose 90% CI clears the benchmark from items whose CI overlaps it (legend); all 13 items exceed it, 11 significantly.

Her earlier course as instructor of record, ECON 5 in Summer 2024 (Figure 2), shows the same pattern. The 2024 SET report itself did not publish a departmental comparison, so the benchmark

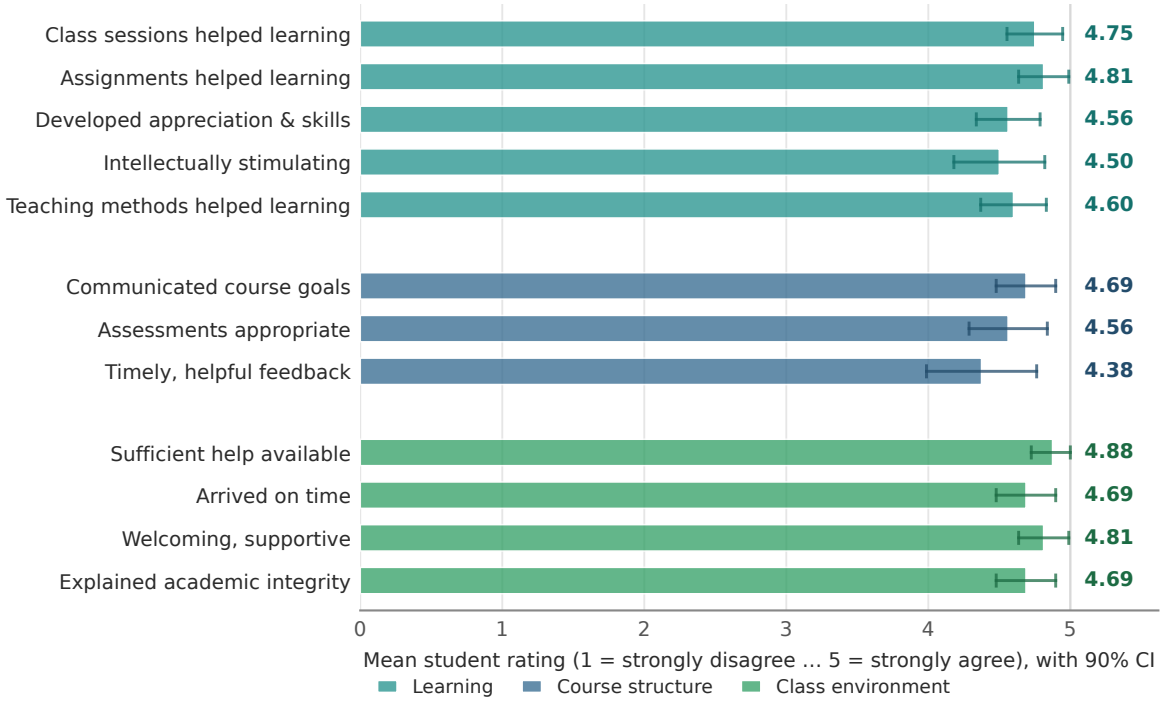
here is reconstructed from the department's own SET records: the leave-one-out average of the other lower-division Economics Summer-Session-I sections that term (three of them). Ida is above the department on all three SET dimensions, the finest level those records report.

**Figure 2.** Instructor of record: ECON 5, Summer 2024 ($n = 16$)

**(a)** SET dimensions vs. the department average




**(b)** Individual survey items within each dimension



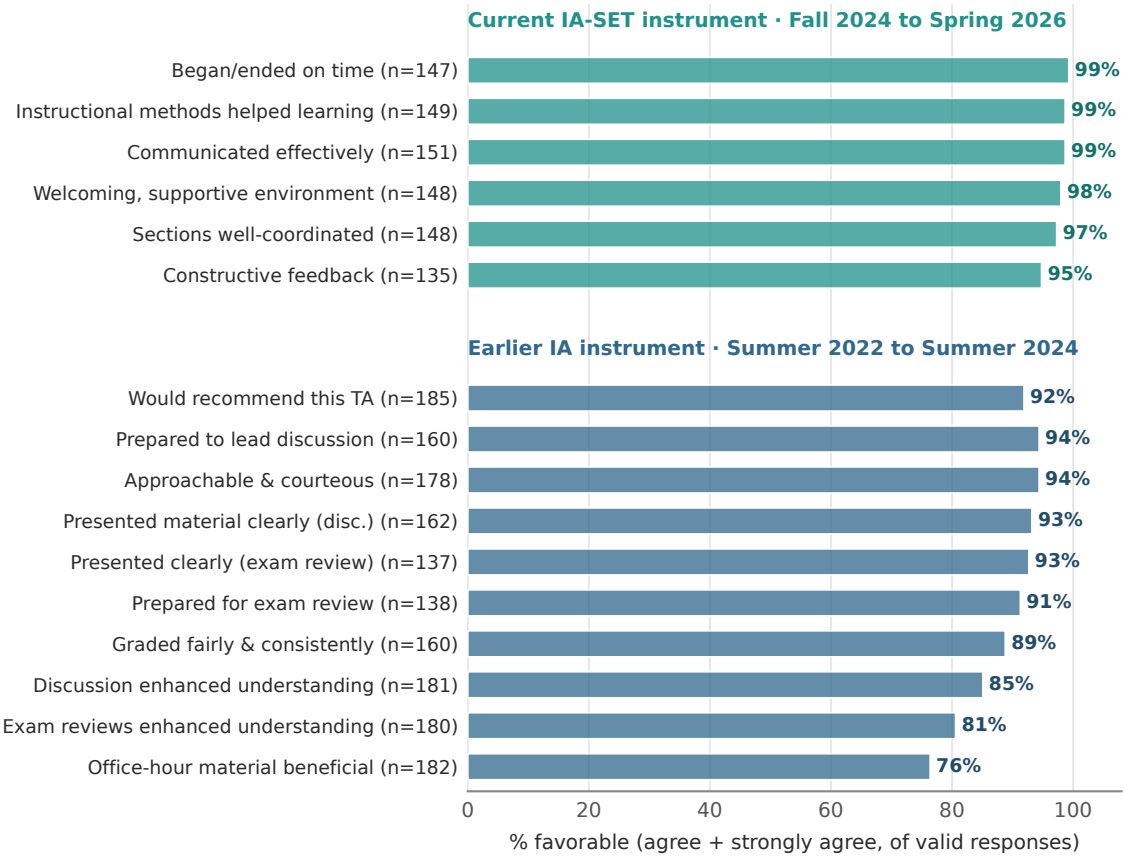

*Notes. Panel (a)* shows Ida's three SET dimension averages (each a composite of the related survey items) with a 90% $t$-CI pooled from her per-response data; bars are shaded by the rule of Figure 1 (whether the 90% CI clears the benchmark or overlaps it), with the same legend. The diamond is the Summer-2024 *lower-division* Economics department average, leave-one-out (the mean of the three other lower-division sections that term), reconstructed from the department's own SET records because the 2024 report did not publish a comparison. *Panel (b)* gives Ida's ratings on each item with 90% CIs; the department does not publish a per-item comparison, so panel (b) does not show a benchmark. Ida is above the department on all three dimensions.

## Teaching and instructional assistant

On the current instructional-assistant instrument (Fall 2024 onward), **95-99% of students** respond favorably on every item, including communication, a welcoming environment, and constructive feedback; on the earlier instrument, favorability ranges from 76% to 94%, with the lowest values on whether

exam-review and office-hour sessions deepened understanding (Figure 3). A variant that credits half of each neutral response, and the underlying mean ratings, are in the appendix (Figure 6 and Figure 7).

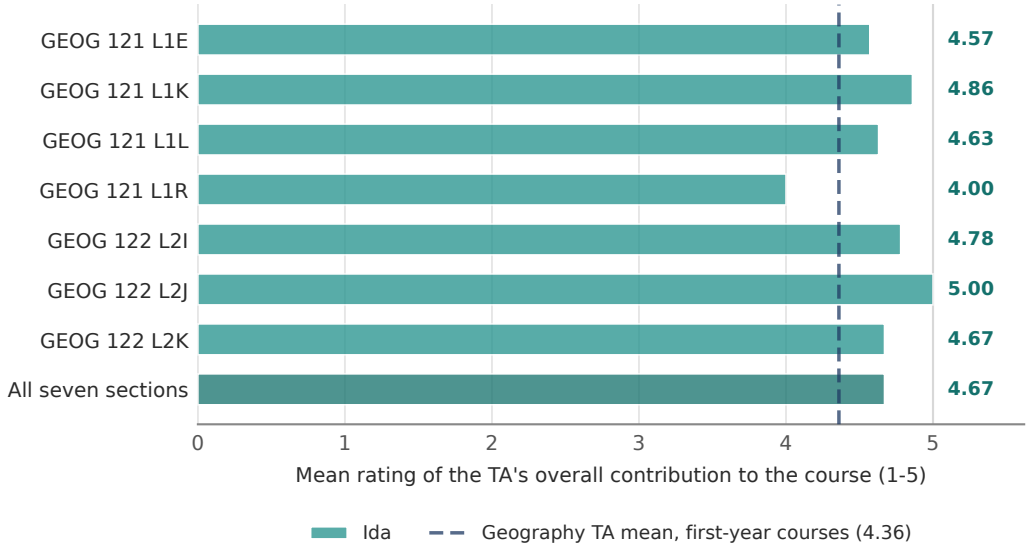
**Figure 3.** Teaching / instructional assistant: share responding favorably, pooled across 18 sections




*Notes.* "Favorable" counts *agree* and *strongly agree* as a share of all valid responses, so a *neutral* response is counted as non-favorable. Figure 6 (appendix) re-computes this crediting half of each neutral as favorable, and Figure 7 (appendix) gives the underlying mean ratings. The two labeled blocks are the current IA-SET instrument and the earlier instrument, whose items differ, so the two are pooled separately. $n$ = pooled valid responses per item.

UC San Diego does not publish a departmental benchmark for instructional-assistant evaluations, so the TA figures above have no benchmark. The one TA evaluation in the record that does have a departmental comparison is from an earlier role at the University of British Columbia (Figure 4). In UBC's official end-of-term TA evaluation surveys for seven first-year Geography sections in 2015-16, students rated Ida's overall course contribution at a 4.67 average, above the department average of 4.36 for TAs in first-year courses (4.25 across all course levels). Ida's rating is above that average in six of the seven sections.

**Figure 4.** TA ratings vs. the Geography mean for first-year courses, UBC 2015-16

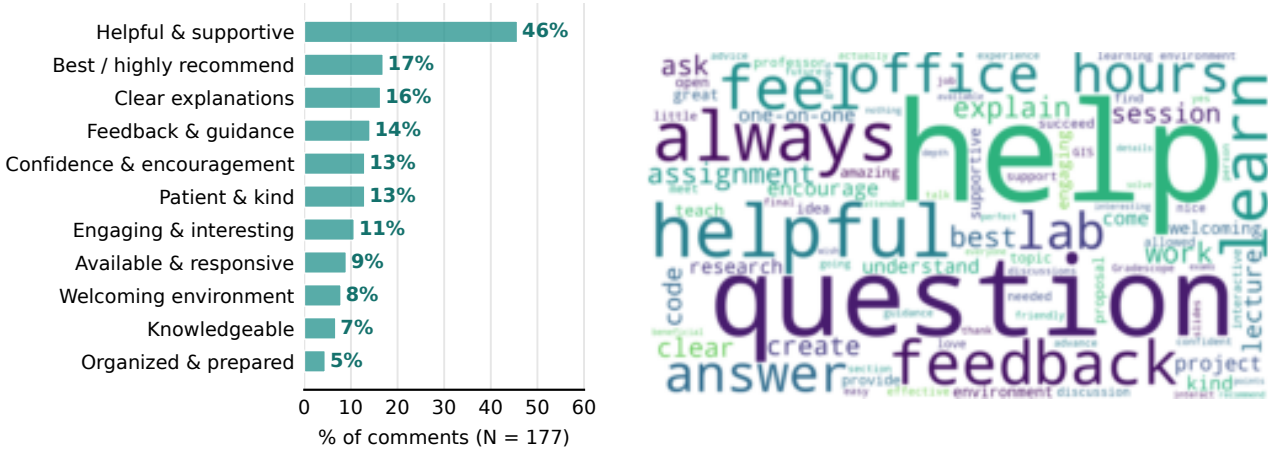



*Notes.* Bars are Ida's mean rating on the report's item "How would you rate the overall contribution of the TA to the course?", by section and across all seven sections (weighted by respondents); the vertical line is the Geography department's mean on the same item in first-year courses that year, the course level of GEOG 121 and 122, which the report asks readers to compare within. It comes from a different institution, instrument, and era than the UCSD figures.

## Student comments

Across the **177 open-ended comments** (students' written answers, including those to the question on what could be improved), **87% are purely positive**. Of the other 13%, 16 comments offer a specific, constructive suggestion (for example, more in-class coding practice, or releasing materials earlier) and seven are critical in tone. Tagged by theme (Figure 5, left), 46% mention help and support, followed by superlatives or a recommendation (17%), clear explanations (16%), and feedback and guidance (14%); the word cloud (Figure 5, right) shows the most frequent words.

**Figure 5.** Open-ended comments, 2025-26




*Notes.* Left: share of 177 open-ended comments (2025-26) mentioning each theme; a comment can match several. Right: the most frequent words after merging inflections (help/helped) and combining phrases ("office hours"), with distinctive adjectives such as "helpful" kept separate.

A few representative comments:

> *Ida was wonderful throughout the summer session, she helped answer every question I had and made class interesting. . . .* **(ECON 5, instructor of record, Summer 2025)**

> *Very interesting and engaging, kept me interested in a subject I was not previously interested in. . . .* **(ECON 121, instructor of record, Summer 2025)**

> *. . . When I first met her, I thought she was already a professor, that's how professional and engaging she was. She is an extremely effective teacher.* **(GPEC 443, GIS & Spatial Data Analysis, TA, Fall 2025)**

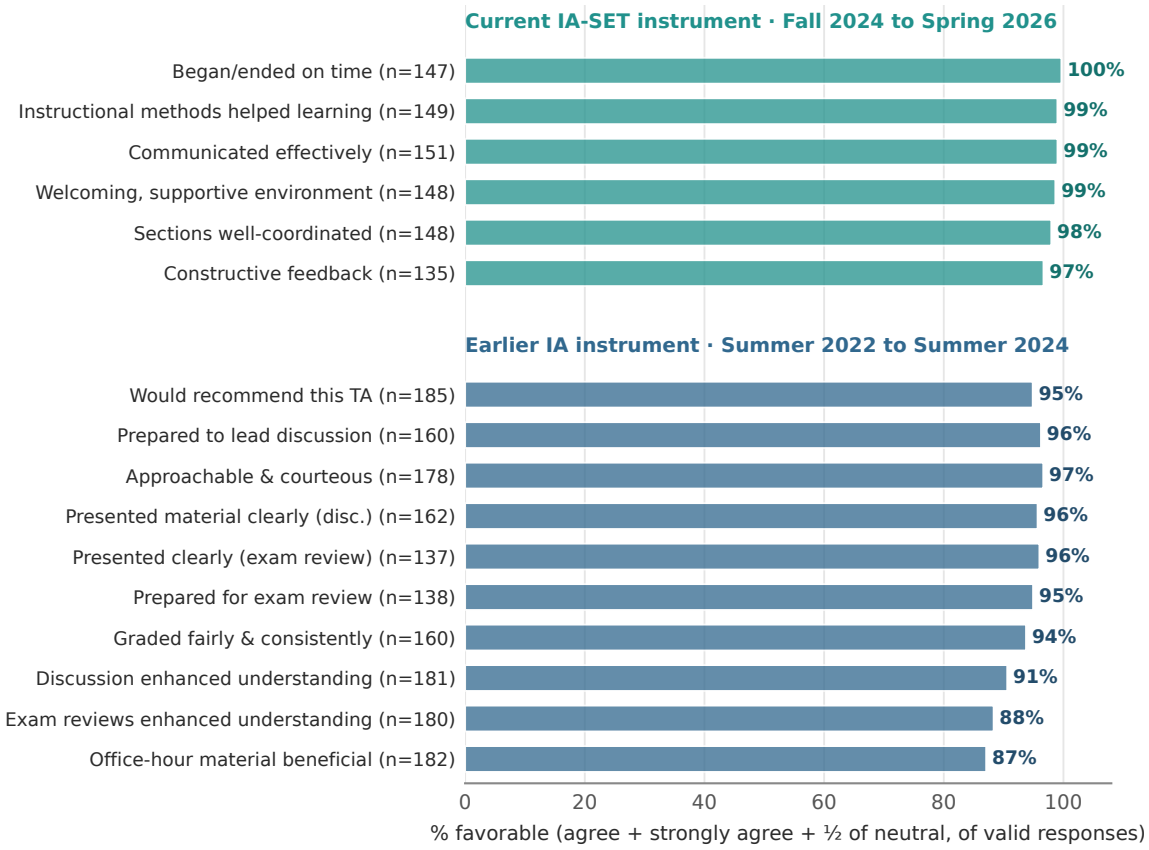
> *I came into this class very nervous, and I doubted my ability to succeed. Ida was one of the first people to make me feel like I can actually do GIS. . . .* **(GPEC 443, TA, Fall 2025)**

> *. . . Talking through my ideas was extremely helpful in . . . refining my research question. . . . you've really pushed me to think further each meeting. . . .* **(ECON 190, Intro to Research in Economics, TA, Winter 2025)**

> *Love her discussion section. Very well organized, effective and engaging. She's also very helpful!* **(ECON 5, TA, Spring 2026)**

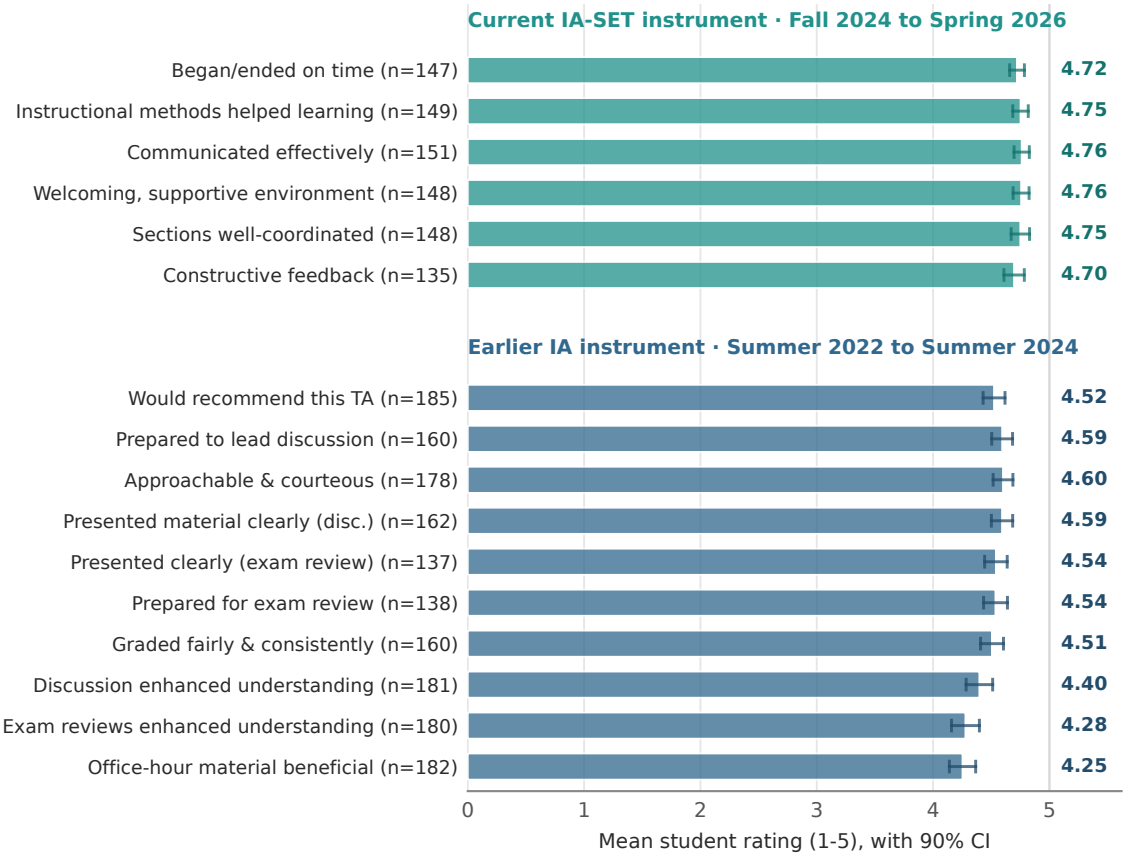
## Appendix

**Figure 6.** Share responding favorably, counting half of each neutral as favorable




*Notes.* This companion to Figure 3 re-computes that figure crediting each neutral response as half-favorable (agree, strongly agree, and half of each neutral, over valid responses), on the assumption that neutrals are a roughly even mix of mild approval and mild disapproval. The two labeled blocks are the current IA-SET instrument and the earlier instrument.

**Figure 7.** Pooled mean ratings with 90% confidence intervals, by instrument




*Notes.* The mean ratings underlying Figure 3, on the 1-5 scale, per item and pooled across sections, with 90% $t$-CIs. UCSD does not publish a departmental benchmark for instructional-assistant evaluations (see Figure 4 for the one external comparison). The two labeled blocks are the current IA-SET instrument and the earlier instrument.

**Notes.** *Sources:* UC San Diego official Student Evaluation of Teaching (SET) and Instructional-Assistant evaluation reports and their per-response data exports, 2022-2026, plus the UBC Geography TA report (2015-16). *Statistics:* bars are means on the 1-5 scale; whiskers are 90% $t$-confidence intervals ($\mathrm{df} = n - 1$), with the upper whisker capped at the scale ceiling of 5.0. "Favorable" counts *agree* and *strongly agree* as a share of valid (excluding "not applicable") responses, so a *neutral* response is counted as non-favorable. The appendix (Figure 6) gives a variant that instead credits half of each neutral. *Bar categories (instructor figures, shades in each legend):* the mean is above the benchmark and the 90% CI lower bound is also above it; the mean is above the benchmark but the CI overlaps it; or the mean is at or below the benchmark. The CI whisker and the value label take their bar's shade. *Benchmarks:* the two Summer-2025 instructor reports publish a per-item departmental comparison. For ECON 5 (Summer 2024), whose report did not publish one, the comparison is the *lower-division* Economics Summer-Session-I department average that term (leave-one-out: the three other lower-division sections), reconstructed from the department's own SET records (every Economics section, extracted from the campus SET system) and shown at the three SET-dimension composites, the finest level those records report. At UBC, the comparison is the Geography department's mean TA rating in first-year courses that year, from the report's own table by course level. UCSD TA/IA reports do not publish a comparison. *Comments:* the 177 comments are the 2025-26 written answers to the four open-ended questions (what helped, what could be improved, the learning environment, anything else), one entry per answer. Answers shorter than 15 characters (mostly "N/A" and "no") are left out. Themes are keyword-tagged. Lists of suggestion and criticism phrases label each comment: *purely positive* when neither list matches, containing a *constructive suggestion*, or *critical*. Every comment was then read against its label, and 12 labels were corrected. The figures and all underlying data are reproduced by code from the evaluation exports.